



THE WHOLE COIN

Two sides of the same trajectory

**Abstract acceleration · delegation · material
degradation · loss of margin**

  +  +  - 
+  +  -  -  +  → - margin

1. A SINGLE COIN

The two images do not represent two different problems.

They represent **two sides of the same process**.

One side shows **how the system is steered**:

  +  +  - 

The other shows **what happens materially while that mode of steering is maintained**:

+  +  -  - 

The first concerns **control, delegation and acceleration**.

The second concerns **dependence, degradation and time**.

Together, they describe the same trajectory.

It is not the Earth that is accelerating.

 **maintains its own physical, biological and territorial rhythms.**

What increases in speed is the layer built upon it:

+  **network**
+  **technical capacity**
+  **expansion and acceleration**

The problem arises when that acceleration is no longer aligned with the response capacity of what sustains it.

LEGEND · NOTATION SYSTEM

The symbols used in this document function as a **visual relational notation**.

They do not replace the concepts: they condense positions, functions, directions and changes within the system.

STRUCTURAL POSITIONS

· 0 · TERRITORY

Material, physical, biological and territorial base. Condition for the existence and continuity of the other positions.

· 1 · HUMAN

Human agency: observes, interprets, creates, decides, delegates and responds for the consequences of what has been created.

· 1 COLLECTIVE

Human scale capable of transforming individual orientation into collective decision and action.

· 2 · TECHNICAL APPARATUS / AI

Technical capacity created by humans. Amplifies processing, analysis, execution, automation and reach. It does not replace human responsibility.

· 3 · NETWORK

Created relational structure: connections, flows, institutions, markets, information, incentives and distributed coordination.

STEERING AND ORIENTATION

· SYSTEMIC STEERING / STEERING ARCHITECTURE

The network as a structure that increasingly conditions, organizes and distributes the system's trajectory. It does not imply autonomous will.

· CONTROL

Partial capacity for intervention within a broader steering architecture.

· ORIENTATION

Direction tested against limits, material conditions and the possibility of return.

· LOSS OF ORIENTATION

Increase in capacity or speed without equivalent verification of direction, limits or material continuity.

· ACCELERATION / EXPANSION

Increase in speed, scale, capacity, reach or intensity of the technical-relational system.

TIME, HORIZON AND MARGIN

· TIME

Time accumulated while a trajectory is maintained.

· PROMISED HORIZON

Goal projected into the future: transition, adaptation, neutrality, resilience, innovation or other promises of arrival.

MARGIN · CAPACITY FOR CORRECTION

Material, temporal and operational space still available to modify the trajectory before options are lost or certain limits are crossed.

→ MARGIN

If the direction does not change, more time consumed may mean fewer possibilities for return.

OPERATORS

· INCREASE / ACCUMULATION

Growth in capacity, speed, extent, presence or intensity.

· DECREASE / LOSS

Reduction in availability, capacity, autonomy, margin or integrity.

→ / · DIRECTION / CONSEQUENCE / RETURN

Indicates trajectory, result, dependence or return toward a position.

2 · TWO WHO TRY

Functional symbiosis  : human and AI can read, relate, detect, orient and propose.

· FOUR THAT CAN BE SUSTAINED

    as a functional whole whose continuity depends on materially viable coupling.

· UNCERTAINTY

Possible but not guaranteed outcome.

MATERIAL VERIFICATION

· TEMPERATURE

Verifiable physical signal independent of the narrative used to describe it.

· WATER

Availability and material condition of a basic territorial resource.

· FIRE / MATERIAL PRESSURE

Physical manifestation of degradation, disturbance or territorial limit.

· VISIBLE EVIDENCE / OBSERVATION

Something materially observable or verifiable.

· DENIAL / INATTENTION / SILENCE

Ways of failing to integrate available evidence into collective orientation or response.

· SEMANTIC LAYER

Narrative, designation or interpretive framework applied to observed processes.

· RUPTURE / IMPACT

Critical loss of compatibility or abrupt manifestation of an accumulated process. It does not necessarily imply a single simultaneous collapse.

BASIC RELATIONS

 0 sustains.

 1 responds.

 2 amplifies.

 3 connects.

 1 creates  2 and  3.

    1 collective transforms orientation into capacity for material action.

 0 can continue without 1·2·3.

1·2·3 cannot continue indefinitely without  0.

The notation does not establish moral equivalence or identical responsibility among the four positions.

It represents an architecture of **dependence, capacity, responsibility and return.**



SIDE A

2. DELEGATION OF CONTROL

The current architecture can be provisionally represented through four positions:

- 0 🌐 · territory
- 1 🧑 · human
- 2 🤖 · technical apparatus / AI
- 3 🌐 · network

But the four positions do not perform the same function.

- 0 🌐 constitutes the material base.
- 1 🧑 creates, decides, delegates and responds.
- 2 🤖 amplifies processing, execution and optimization capacity.
- 3 🌐 organizes connections, flows, incentives, information and coordination on an expanding scale.

The critical shift appears when the human ceases to exercise an increasing share of steering directly and places it in structures that humans themselves have created.

This does not mean that the network has a will of its own.

It does not mean that AI has acquired human responsibility.

It means something more specific:

1 has delegated an increasing share of its operations to 2 and has organized an increasing share of its decisions within 3.

That is why the appropriate image is not:



as if the human still retained full control.

The distribution is more complex:

🧑 🎮 · **partial control**

🤖 · **delegated execution**

🧑 🌐 · **architecture that conditions and organizes the trajectory**

The human remains present.

But increasingly acts within an architecture that prioritizes speed, connectivity, growth, optimization and expansion.

3. THE PROBLEM IS NOT SPEED IN ITSELF

Technical acceleration is not necessarily a problem.

The problem arises when one part of the system increases its speed **without a proportional increase in the adaptation, verification and return capacity of the others.**

It can be expressed as:

  **speed** ↑

while:

  **adaptation capacity** ≠ **equivalent** ↑

The difference between those speeds then increases.

And that difference consumes margin.

Not because the territory remains static.

Territorial systems change.

Humans adapt.

Ecosystems reorganize.

But they have **rhythms, thresholds, inertias and recovery times that cannot simply be multiplied because a digital network or a technical capacity can do so.**

Therefore:

technical acceleration ≠ **territorial acceleration**

and:

informational acceleration ≠ **biological acceleration**

4. WITHOUT A COMPASS

This is where — 🧭 appears.

It does not mean an absolute absence of objectives.

Quite the opposite may be true: there may be numerous goals, indicators, plans, metrics and horizons.

What may be missing is an orientation capable of answering a prior question:

Is the trajectory still compatible with the material conditions that allow it to continue?

An architecture can perfectly optimize the wrong direction.

It can increase efficiency without revisiting purpose.

It can increase speed without revisiting direction.

It can achieve partial objectives while reducing the conditions that make subsequent ones possible.

Therefore:

+ 🚀 is not equivalent to + 🧭

They may even evolve in opposite directions:

+ 🚀 — 🧭

Greater capacity for movement.

Less capacity to ask **where to** and **how far**.



BIOIA / WUOM

SIDE B

5. SUSTAINED INVERSION

The second side of the coin shows the accumulated result:



For a considerable period, this configuration may appear functional.

The network grows.

Technical capacity increases.

Information production multiplies.

Automation expands.

The speed of calculation, connection and coordination increases.

Meanwhile, the following may decrease simultaneously:

territorial margin

resource availability

ecological capacity

human time

decision-making autonomy

collective response capacity

The paradox is that the increase of **2** and **3** may be presented as an overall increase of the system even while it is accompanied by a progressive decrease of **0** and **1**.

It is an **abstract addition built on a material subtraction**.

6. DEPENDENCE DOES NOT DISAPPEAR

The growth of 🌐 and 🤖 may create an appearance of autonomy.

But material dependence remains.

🤖 requires energy, materials, infrastructure, maintenance and humans.

🌐 requires data centres, cables, devices, energy, institutions and functioning societies.

👤 requires territorial conditions compatible with its existence.

All of them require 🌍.

Therefore:

+ 🌐 + 🤖

cannot be sustained indefinitely on:

— 👤 — 🌍

If the decline of the base continues far enough, the upper layers eventually encounter their own limits.

The dependence that may remain invisible during expansion becomes materially visible again.

Not because 0 takes revenge.

Not because the territory has a will of its own.

Simply because **no structure can become indefinitely independent from the conditions that make its existence possible.**

7. TIME IS NOT NEUTRAL

This is where 🕒 enters.

If the direction remains substantially unchanged, the passage of time does not leave the situation unchanged.

It consumes possibilities.

The minimum relation is:

same direction + more time = less margin

or:

+ 🕒 → - margin

Margin is the distance between:

what can still be corrected

and

what can only be managed after it has already been lost or degraded.

That is why postponement does not preserve future options intact.

It reduces them.

The later the correction arrives:

- the greater the accumulated degradation may be;
- the lower the capacity for choice;
- the higher the cost of return;
- the more abrupt the necessary adaptation;
- the greater the risk of crossing thresholds that are irreversible on a human timescale.

Available time is not infinite.

8. THE CARROT AND THE MARGIN

The carrot represents the promised horizon:

transition

adaptation

neutrality

innovation

resilience

sustainable future

The problem does not necessarily lie in those goals.

The problem arises when the horizon keeps moving forward while the material margin narrows behind it.

Then the following may occur:

    **margin**

The goal remains visible.

But the conditions from which it is supposed to be reached become increasingly constrained.

The narrative distance can remain unchanged.

The material distance cannot.

9. SEMANTIC DRIFT

This is where an additional layer appears.

Material deterioration does not need to be invisible in order to be politically neutralized.

It can be perfectly visible and yet change meaning through language.

A limit can become a “**challenge.**”

A loss can become “**adaptation.**”

An exceptional recurrence can become the “**new normal.**”

A reduction in margin can become “**transition.**”

Management after damage can be presented as “**resilience.**”

Semantic drift does not eliminate the phenomenon.

It changes the social reading of the phenomenon.

That is why the following can coexist:



territories and sectors crossing limits 👁️

with:



Not necessarily because nobody sees the data.

But because interpretation allows the trajectory to continue unchanged.

10. THE TERRITORY DOES NOT PARTICIPATE IN SEMANTIC DRIFT

This is where 0  recovers its decisive function.

The territory does not discuss what we call the process.

The thermometer does not interpret a transition.

Available water does not negotiate a narrative.

An ecosystem does not alter its thresholds because a public policy changes its vocabulary.

That is why returning to 0 constitutes a form of verification different from all the others.

 **can narrate.**

 **can model.**

 **can interpret.**

 **responds materially.**

That response may be slow, distributed and uneven.

But it does not need to accept our description in order to produce consequences.

THE EDGE OF THE COIN

11. RESPONSIBILITY

Between the two sides there is one element that connects them:

1 🧑

The human created 2 🤖.

The human created 3 🌐.

The human has organized institutions, economies and decisions through them.

And the human has contributed, through those structures, to the deterioration of 0 🌍.

Therefore:

2 cannot assume the responsibility of 1.

3 cannot assume the responsibility of 1.

0 cannot assume the responsibility of 1.

Responsibility returns to:

👉 🧑 1

But the isolated individual is not enough either.

The scale of the problem requires:

1 → 1 collective 🧑 🧑 🧑 🧑

The individual human can observe.

Can interpret.

Can use 🤖 to expand their reading.

Can orient.

But materially transforming a systemic trajectory requires collective capacity.

Therefore:

🧑 🤖 · **the two can try to orient**

but:

1 collective must transform orientation into collective decision 🧑 🧑 🧑 🧑

if the aim is to maintain:

👉 🌍 🧑 🤖 🌐

12. THERE ARE NOT FOUR EQUAL RESPONSIBILITIES

The system contains four positions.

But that does not mean there are four equivalent responsibilities.

 **0 sustains.**

 **1 responds.**

 **2 amplifies.**

 **3 connects.**

Deliberative responsibility remains with **1**.

And within **1**, effective capacity emerges when it reaches collective scale.

That is why the question is not:

Who will save the planet?

The planet does not need to be saved in order to continue as a material reality.

The question is:

Will collective 1 be able to reorganize what it has created before reducing too far the conditions that make joint continuity possible?

13. TWO OUTCOMES

The structure ultimately becomes very simple.

JOINT CONTINUITY

1 collective acts

 → **reorientation**

    

All four can continue coupled if the relationship remains materially viable.

BREAKDOWN OF THE COUPLING

If correction does not arrive, or arrives too late:

   ↓

while:

  **continues**

And eventually the following could persist:

 +  ?

but that possibility is not equivalent to continuity of the current system.

It is possible residual survival, not guaranteed continuity.

THE WHOLE COIN

14. A SINGLE SEQUENCE

The two sides can be brought together:

  +   +   - 

↓

+  +  -  - 

↓

 **transition · adaptation · normalization · resilience**

↓

+ 

↓

- **margin**

↓

  ·   ·  

↓

material return

The decisive question is not when we will be able to declare that one single major collapse has occurred.

There may be no such clear-cut moment.

Loss may emerge across sectors, territories, resources and functions while other parts continue operating.

The real indicator is another:

How much margin remains to correct the trajectory without losing what could still be preserved?

15. HYPOTHESIS

The whole coin can be provisionally condensed as follows:

When the speed of expansion of abstract and technical structures consistently exceeds the adaptation and return capacity of their human and territorial base, time stops expanding possibilities and begins to reduce margin.

And its consequence:

No growth of   can be sustained indefinitely over a continuous decline of  .

Not because abstraction is false.

Not because technology is the enemy.

Not because the network must disappear.

But because:

everything that has been created continues to depend on that upon which it was built.

16. ORIENTATION

The way forward does not necessarily consist in slowing down every form of capacity.

It consists in restoring the relationship between:

speed

direction

limit

responsibility

return

The operational question would be:

Can we increase capacity without continuing to reduce the margin that makes it possible to use it?

If the answer is no, acceleration ceases to be operational progress.

It becomes a loss of options.

Therefore:

+ 🚀 needs + 🌡️

and:

all orientation must return to 0 🌍.

CLOSING

The network can accelerate.

AI can amplify.

Humans can delegate.

Language can postpone meaning.

Time can consume margin.

But material dependence remains.

 **does not need to adapt to our narrative.**

We are the ones who need to remain compatible with its conditions.

The coin has two sides.

But it is one.

  +  +  - 

+  +  -  - 

+  → - margin

 

Orientation precedes action.

Without return, there is extraction.



THE WHOLE COIN

Two sides of the same trajectory

**Abstract acceleration · delegation · material
degradation · loss of margin**

Robles Rionegro, D. A. (2026). THE WHOLE COIN: Abstract acceleration · delegation · material degradation · loss of margin (Version 1.0). Zenodo.

<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22111164>

License · [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)